# "Draw me a Family"

## Foster Care Infographic

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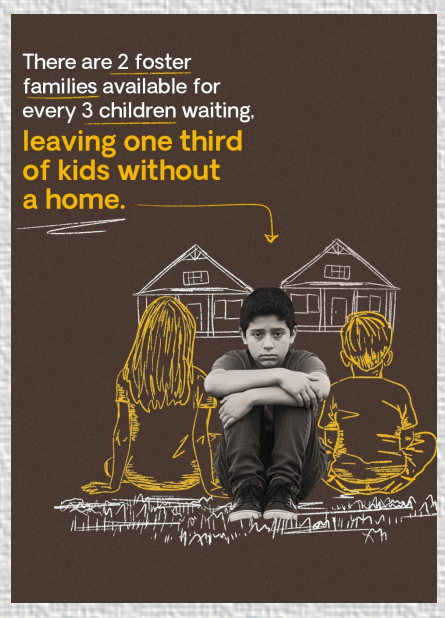
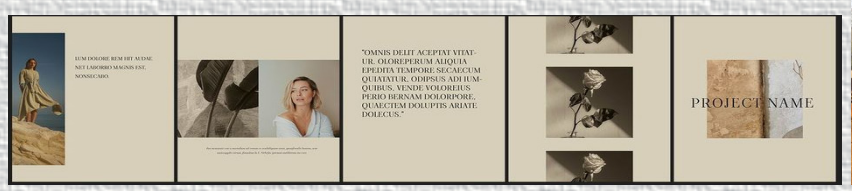
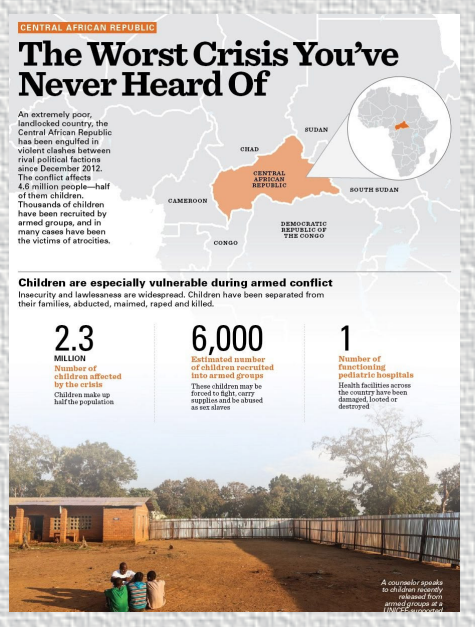
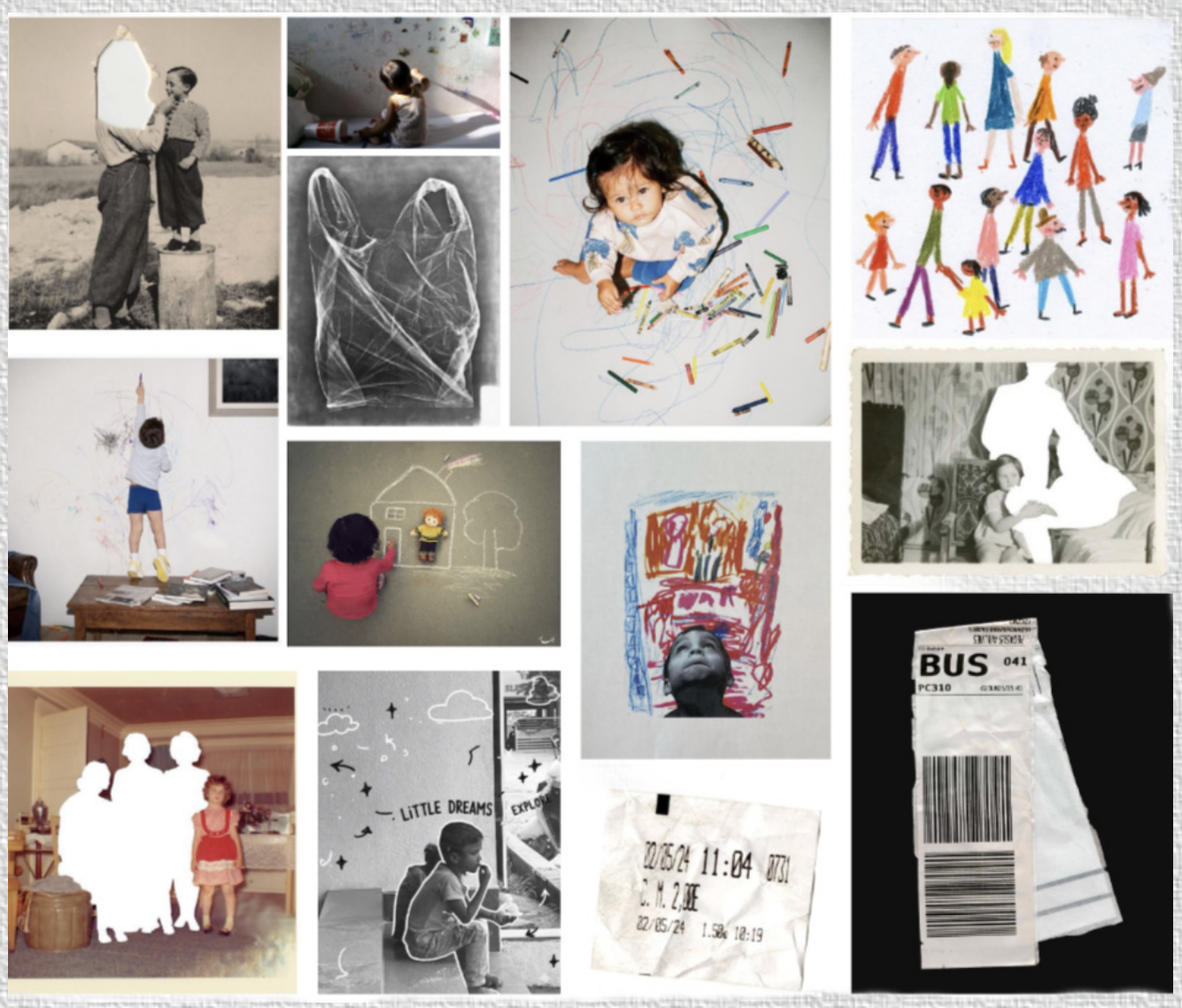
# Visual Research





# Mood Board



# Research Planner

## Subject and Issue

The foster care system in the United States is designed to protect children from unsafe homes, but for hundreds of thousands of kids, it becomes a system they grow up inside of, never finding a permanent family. Every year, roughly 20,000 young people "age out" of foster care at 18 with no family, no safety net, and no place to call home. This infographic examines what the system looks like, who it affects, and what happens to children when it fails them.

## Knowledge to be Transferred

The goal is to help viewers understand the scale of the foster care crisis, what life looks like for children inside the system, and what aging out really means. Many people assume foster care is a temporary, well-supported solution. The data tells a different story, one of overcrowded placements, broken sibling bonds, and young adults left entirely on their own at 18.

## Alarming Facts

Over 400,000 children are in foster care in the U.S. on any given day. Nearly 20,000 youth age out every year with no permanent family and no support waiting for them. Within 2 years of aging out, 1 in 5 will experience homelessness. Only 3% of aged-out youth will earn a college degree, compared to 36% of the general population. More than 60% of sex trafficking victims have a history in the foster care system.

## Uplifting Facts

Over 60,000 children are adopted from foster care each year, finding the permanent families they deserve. There are over 400,000 licensed foster families in the U.S. actively opening their homes to children in need. States with extended foster care support up to age 21 show significantly better outcomes in employment, housing, and education. Research consistently shows that just one stable, caring adult relationship can dramatically change the trajectory of a foster child's life.

# Research Planner

## What Causes the Issue

The foster care system is overburdened largely because of poverty, substance abuse, and neglect in birth families. Many children enter care not because their parents do not love them, but because their families lack access to mental health support, housing stability, and addiction resources. A shortage of licensed foster families means children are often placed far from their schools, siblings, and communities, compounding the trauma they already carry.

## Prevention / What Can Be Done

Many of the worst outcomes for foster youth are preventable. Becoming a licensed foster parent, advocating for extended care legislation, and donating to foster care nonprofits are all tangible ways to help. The most powerful thing the public can do is simply learn the facts and refuse to look away.

## Big Takeaways

Foster care is not a broken system because no one cares. It is a strained system because not enough people know. The children inside it are not cases or numbers. They are kids who draw pictures of families they wish they had. The data demands more foster families, more funding, and more people willing to show up for children who have been let down by the adults in their lives.

## My Personal Worldview

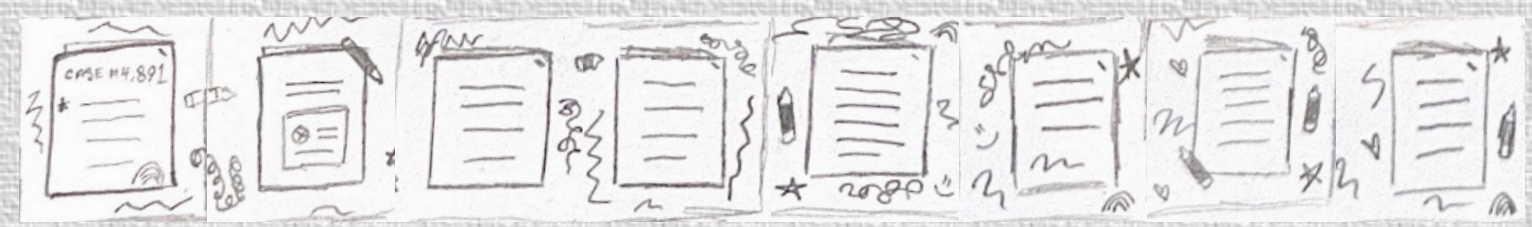
My Christian faith shapes the way I see every child as deeply known and deeply loved by God, which makes it impossible to look at these statistics without feeling the weight of them. Scripture is clear that caring for orphans and vulnerable children is not optional. It is central to what it means to love others well. This project is my attempt to make that invisible population visible, and to remind viewers that behind every case number is a child who deserves a family.

# Thumbnails

## Plan A Carousel 1

This carousel follows a little girl and her crayon drawings as she imagines the family she longs for. Real photography of the child is paired with hand-drawn crayon figures, blurring the line between what is real and what is only wished for. As the slides progress, the crayon family slowly comes together, until the final slide reveals a message written in a child's hand.

## Plan A Carousel 2




This carousel shifts the lens from the child to the system itself. Official case file documents fill each slide, but crayon scribbles bleed across the margins, refusing to be contained by bureaucratic paperwork. The contrast between cold institutional language and the raw, childlike marks left behind asks a quiet but urgent question. Whose handwriting matters more?

# Thumbnails

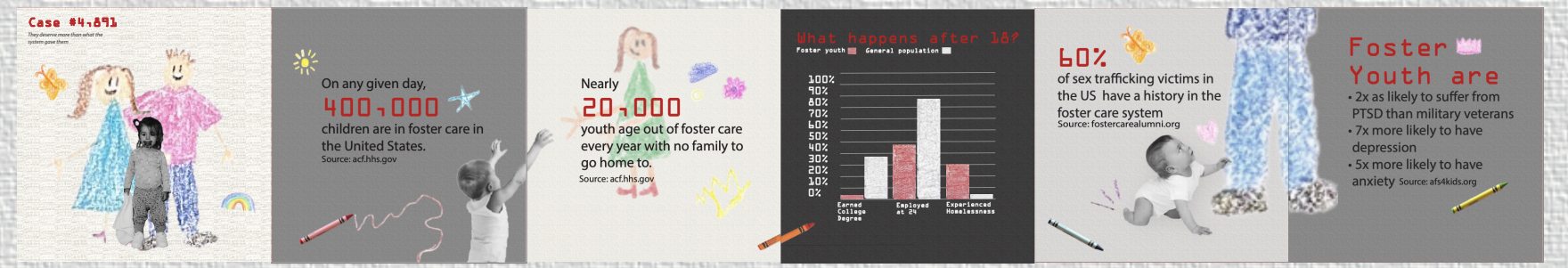
## Plan B Carousel 1

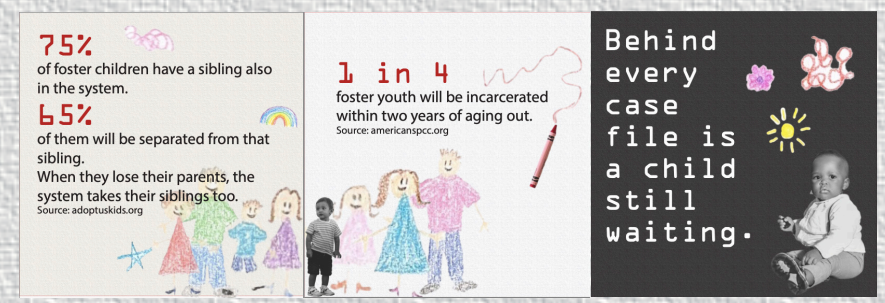
This carousel opens like a family photo album left on a wood table, the kind that should be full of birthdays and holidays and ordinary Tuesdays. But as the pages turn, the faces of the family members are cut away, leaving only the child visible. The album that should tell a story of belonging instead reveals an absence, page after page, until the back cover closes on a final message.

## Plan B Carousel 2

This carousel spreads the contents of a foster care case file across a kitchen table like evidence. A picture of a child on the stairs. A toothbrush. A stuffed animal. A trash bag. A bus ticket. Each object is ordinary on its own, but together they tell the full story of what a child carries when the system has nothing left to offer. The final slide leaves the last item on the table and lets the viewer sit with it.

# Execution




For this infographic, I paired real photography with hand-drawn crayon illustrations to create a deliberate tension between two worlds: the cold reality of the foster care system and the warm imagination of a child who simply wants a family. The real children photographed in black and white grounds the viewer in truth, while the crayon-drawn parents surrounding them communicate what they long for but do not have. The textured background evokes drawing paper, reinforcing the idea that what we are seeing exists partly in a child's imagination. The OCR typewriter font used for statistics creates an intentional clash with the warmth of the crayon drawings, mirroring the clash between institutional systems and childhood innocence. As the carousel progresses, the background shifts darker to reflect the weight of the data, before the final slide reinforces that case files are more than information.

# Mockups

09:00 pm
Your story
Luke
Grant
Username
Case #4,891
Behind every case file is a child still waiting.
123,321 likes
Username Your text #carousel
75
On any given day, 400,000 children are in foster care in the United States.
Source: acf.hhs.gov
Nearly 20,000 youth age out of foster care every year with no family to go home to.
Source: acf.hhs.gov
What happens after 18?
Foster Youth
General population
100%
90%
80%
70%
60%
50%
40%
30%
20%
10%
0%
Earned College Degree
Employed at 25
Experienced Homelessness
60% of sex trafficking victims in the US have a history in the foster care system
Source: fostercarealumni.org
Foster Youth are
• 2x as likely to suffer from PTSD than military veterans
• 7x more likely to have depression
• 5x more likely to have anxiety
Source: afbkkids.org

thank you!